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Charles McPherson

Charles McPherson has been one of the top alto saxophonists in jazz since the 1960s. He was born in Joplin, Missouri on July 24, 1939 and moved to New York City at the age of 20. One of his first gigs was with bassist Charles Mingus, and this fruitful relationship lasted until 1974. While his playing reflects the influences of Johnny Hodges and Charlie Parker, he has developed a distinctive character on the alto that has in turn influenced numerous younger saxophone artists. Charles has recorded frequently throughout his career, often with pianist Barry Harris. He has led his own ensembles since 1972 and can be heard with his son Chuck on drums. Author Stanley Crouch sums up the deep sense of purpose he brings to his music in the liner notes to "First Flight Out." Crouch states, "McPherson never lets us forget the actual greatness of the art he represents."

Charles was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 12, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We're interviewing Charles McPherson today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive — great saxophonist and composer. And I'm very pleased to have you here.

CM: Well thank you.

MR: You are a fellow I've listened to over the years myself.

CM: Well thank you.

MR: Along with Cannonball and Charlie Parker, and you were on my playlist.

CM: Oh, well I'm in good company.

MR: So it's a pleasure. I wanted to actually listen to something here. I got this — [audio interlude]

CM: That's "First Flight Out," Tom Harrell and Peter Washington, Victor Lewis on drums, Michael Weiss on piano and myself, and did I say Tom Harrell?

MR: Right. Could I ask you about how you start a tune, and how it finds its way to completion with a tune like that?

CM: The writing of it?

MR: Yeah.

CM: Well writing is not always easy for me, because I have so much fun playing the saxophone, and practicing the saxophone. When I need to write, I have to force myself to stop playing the saxophone and think about writing. And it's like for me, like writing a letter, which doesn't come easy for me, until I just keep persevering. And then it happens. So writing music for me is pretty much the same way. I will labor over a tune over four or five bars for a couple of days or something, and it's like pulling teeth. And then after a while it happens and then it flows. So I always promise myself that I will never get out of

shape for the act of writing. But I always do. And then if I have deadlines, like record dates, or if I'm commissioned to do something where I must write, then I will, and then I always go through this period of a week or two you know, and then it works, and then it's fun. I'll stay up all night doing it because it's actually fun. But until it flows, it's the loneliest, most miserable thing you know. But when it happens it happens.

MR: Do you start with your horn or at the piano?

CM: Both. Quite often I will have the horn in my lap, I will be sitting at the piano, and I might be playing the piano and then I'll play the horn. Quite often. Sometimes I'm maybe just with the horn and not the piano, or vice versa, I've written tunes like that. Quite often for me the most natural flowing ideas happen when I'm not with the horn or the piano, when I'm walking down the street, or if I'm cutting the grass. I will get the best ideas and then, when this happens you have to remember it, or you have to run in the house—

MR: Turn off the lawn mower and get inside.

CM: Yes. You go jot it down or go play it on the whatever. But it's an interesting thing how that creative process works, at least for some people. And the best ideas always come when you're not trying for them, at least for me. The minute I say I'm going to write now, I must write, there's almost this automatic mental block that comes up. It's just like trying to remember something, and you try, and then the minute you say okay forget it, then, oh, here it is.

MR: Right. Growing up — in Missouri, correct? Did the music that you heard during your childhood have an effect on your eventual choice to be a jazz musician?

CM: Oh I'm sure it did, since everything is connected. I grew up in Joplin, Missouri, which is a little small town south of St. Louis, it's in the southwest corner of Missouri. It borders Oklahoma and Arkansas. And I was there up until about nine years of age then I moved to Detroit. But during the time that I was there, I did have occasion to see various bands, probably coming from Kansas City. They were probably territorial bands. And you know I was a kid so this is when I was like maybe five, six, seven, eight. And every year in the summertime these bands would come to this park in Joplin and play for like a week. And I was quite impressed with the bands, with the music and with the way the horns look, you know, just the physicalities of the nice, gold, shiny horn. And I did like the music, but I didn't start playing until I was about 13, in Detroit. And I moved from Joplin, Missouri to Detroit in 1948, I was about nine. And then in junior high school, like intermediate school, I started playing music.

MR: Did you come from a big family?

CM: No, I'm an only child. My mother is quite musical, and I think when she was a kid she played piano. But I didn't hear it, I didn't have that around me as a kid. My father, I don't think he was as musical as my mom, but he did dabble a little bit, but nothing serious. So

I would imagine that I might have gotten whatever I've gotten from my mom, I would say so. She's a natural — how do you say — well she loves music and she truly feels music. It really does something for her. I can tell by the way she listens. And I think, whatever I got is probably from her.

MR: Right. So the saxophone, junior high you started on the saxophone. Did you take to it right away?

CM: Oh, right away, yeah. I mean that was my instrument of choice. I first started playing a flugelhorn, which is like a trumpet, because they had no saxophones available at school. So I played flugelhorn for about a year, pretty close to that. And then my mom bought me an alto at 13. So actually I started at 12 with the trumpet/flugelhorn. And then saxophone at 13. And I wanted saxophone, I knew that's what I wanted to play. And when I actually started playing, I knew then that I wanted to play music. I knew at 13 this is what I wanted to do.

MR: Did they have a big band or a jazz type group that you could get into?

CM: At this time, during the 50s, this was like early — mid 50s, jazz, you didn't have jazz in the schools. There were no jazz programs, no North Texas State, Berklee or any other. So that was unheard of in those days. So we just played the regular school type things. We played marches and played for football games and for auditorium, morning auditorium and all that. We didn't play any — we had no charts or jazz charts or any of that. But that was fun, I mean that's all we had and it was fun doing that. It was fun playing. And I really liked it, I mean this is what I wanted to do. And I remember there were some jazz records around my house, but not a lot. It wasn't that my people were really jazz fans per se, but there were some things around the house and I liked that. And I did get interested in jazz and a little student at school told me about Charlie Parker. I'd never heard of him you know. And he said, "You should really check this Charlie Parker out." And I did. I went to a little candy shop in my neighborhood and on the juke box there was a Charlie Parker record, a little 45. And I think he was playing "Tico Tico," which is just a Brazilian samba type song. And it just blew me away. I knew immediately that this is what I wanted to do. It made perfect sense to me. I didn't need to be nurtured or taught how to listen to this music. I mean it made perfect sense. And I remember, I was about 14, that to me, when I heard that, and I had no history of hearing a lot of jazz records, I had no concept of what's considered bebop and modern jazz or any of that. It was like, well this is the way music should go. This is the way instrumentals or an instrumentalist, this is the way they should approach this. Automatically. I knew nothing. I mean I felt that. And then I immediately said okay, well I've got to get these records. And then I was told that well you know, this guy is a member of a group of musicians that play a certain genre of jazz music, a certain genre of jazz, and it's called bebop, and there's a whole

slew of these guys. There was like a school of them. So I said oh? That's what that is. So then I said okay, because I had no idea that Charlie Parker represented anything but he's a jazz musician. I knew nothing about schools and styles. And then I just zeroed in on that, and of course then you've got all the modern jazz people from that era. And then I was fortunate in that I just happened to live on the street that had a great jazz club, the best jazz club in Detroit, a local jazz club. And it was four or five blocks down the street. And when I found out that this type of music was played in this club exclusively, then it was like oh — and then I would go and listen. I was too young to get in, I would go listen. And at that time, this was like '56, '57, Miles Davis was in Detroit, this was during that period when Miles lived in Detroit for about two years. And he lived right in this neighborhood where I lived and where this club was, and I would see him every day in the afternoon, walking, going to the store or going about his business. And I remember seeing Miles and I knew who he was. At this time I knew that oh, this is Miles Davis and he played with Charlie Parker and he's living here in Detroit. And it was just great. I mean the house band was Tommy Flanagan, Barry Harris, Elvin Jones, Miles Davis was working at that club. It was heaven.

MR: Wasn't there Thad Jones and Billy Mitchell and those guys?

CM: Thad Jones also. Billy, that's right. Thad Jones, Billy Mitchell, Pepper Adams.

MR: Good atmosphere for music.

CM: Yeah, that was the local band. In fact it was Thad Jones and Pepper Adams. Barry Harris was playing piano, and Elvin was the drummer, Elvin Jones. Beans Richardson I think was the bass player. And Miles would work there often. And this was the scene at this place. People like Wardell Gray would work there, because they would come in and play with the rhythm section. Billy Mitchell, Sonny Stitt. And then when people would be coming to Detroit working at other clubs, they would always come by this club, and hang out or play or sit in. So it was great. And just to hear that kind of virtuosity. I'd never heard that before. And to sneak in there, or hide in the corner and just to hear — I'd never heard people play instruments like that. You know what I mean? So it was shocking, but it was like, oh, yeah, this is what I wanted to be.

MR: Well nowadays we have many places you can go to school to learn jazz and so forth, and we can talk about that later, but you were sparked by that interest. So now how are you going to go about pursuing it, if you're 14, 15?

CM: Well the piano player that worked at that club, his name is Barry Harris. And Barry of course is still around. He should be probably one of the guys you talk to, because he's a teacher.

MR: I saw him at a little clinic in New York a few weeks ago.

CM: He's very popular doing this. And anyway, Barry was into formulating a concept of teaching, way back then, this was in the late 50s, probably '58, '59. It was in a seminal form, but he was already thinking about how do you — because I had sat in in the club, and I guess he figured this boy might have some kind of talent but he doesn't know what he's doing. And I didn't. I didn't know about theory, harmony and I didn't know all these things that you should know and need to know. And he said, "Well you know, come by my house one time and I'll show you some things." And he lived right around the corner as well. So my whole musical life, or the beginnings, were all set in place. And I started coming over to his house, and he showed me about scales and chords and how they function and why they are what they are and how they work and all that. And that was the beginning. And then I started studying. I studied privately for a while for about six months from a good saxophone teacher. So I had a good saxophone teacher that wasn't teaching jazz, he was teaching saxophone. Barry Harris was the jazz guy so I was getting that. And I realized that in order to play with that kind of virtuosity you have to really get into some studying for that. And so I did. And I got real serious about music then. I mean I started getting more serious in school in the band class. It was like okay, this is serious. And then that was it. I knew I wanted to do it, and I went about finding out — I had a good teacher, Barry Harris, I studied with this real good saxophone teacher for a while, and then I studied with Barry for four or five years.

MR: Were your parents supportive of this interest?

CM: Well my mom was, yeah. My mom and father divorced when I was six years old. So my mother was supportive. She did not really think that music was a great profession, because she thought oh you should do this as a hobby, this life is too precarious, it's not reliable. And she's right. She was right. But nevertheless I wanted to do it and I did it.

MR: Didn't have a choice.

CM: Well I wanted to do it. And what does a kid know about it you know? But I wanted to do it so I just did what I was supposed to do. And I've learned — in those days we did not have the schools and curriculum and that kind of thing, so you learn from people like Barry Harris, you learn from the streets, you learn from the world of music. You'd get records and copy them and transcribe and listen to records, and then trial and error and then by jove, you'd finally get it, hopefully.

MR: The name Lonnie Hillyer comes up.

CM: Yeah. Lonnie lived right on my street. He's about almost a year younger. He died in 1985. Very, very talented. Very, you know he's one of these guys that you always read about, you always read about this prototype talented person, died young, no one knew who in the heck he was. I mean there are of course — some musicians know. But he never got any recognition, he never was involved in any real say visible records. He did

make a record with Yusef Lateef, he might have been involved with James Moody on a record or something like that, but he never, he was kind of a tragic figure. He never just got his just due and he wasn't around long enough. And then, it's kind of sad. But anyway he was my best friend. Very talented. Very, very talented. And he just died in 1985, a young man. He was about 45. It was just one of those things. We went to New York together, as far as working with Mingus, yes. Yeah, we worked, let's see this was around 1959 or '60. And there used to be a little coffee shop in the Village called the Cafe Wha?. And there were people I can remember folk singing was very popular at this time, as well as the jazz. And quite often they would have folk singing and jazz in the same club. In fact there's a guy, Peter, Paul and Mary, there was a guy named Noel Stookey — he actually changed his name, he was either Peter or Paul.

MR: Peter Stookey, right. No, it's not, it's Paul Stookey.

CM: Well I knew him as Noel. Oh, okay. All right. Now he was just a folk singer singing, playing his guitar, and then we had this jam session in the afternoon, and Bill Cosby or people like that or even Bob Dylan would be at some coffee house across the street, and everybody was just like struggling nonentities basically, really. And so in the afternoon we'd have these sessions. And Mingus came by one afternoon because he was in need of an alto player and a trumpet player. And we were recommended by Yusef, who worked with Mingus sometimes, and Eric Dolphy and a guy named Ted Curson, trumpet player, both respectively were going to quit Mingus and get their own groups. And so Mingus needed a saxophone player in there. And he was really mad at Eric and both of those guys. But anyway he came to the session in the afternoon and heard us and he hired us. He told us, "Well come to the club tonight and bring your horns and we'll see what happens." And Eric Dolphy was still there, because they had two weeks notice. So for about two weeks there were two altos and two trumpets in Mingus' band. And Mingus, every night, tried to get Eric not to quit. Because Eric really played Mingus' music well. And he had been working with Mingus a long time. And Mingus' music was extremely difficult. It takes a long time to teach people these songs and then here Eric is going to quit. But anyway, the memorable thing that happened is Lonnie and I were in this club, owned by a gangster, definitely that scene. And we were in the club and it was at the end of the evening. And these people owed Mingus about two thousand dollars. That was the first time Lonnie and I had been in the company of Mingus like this. And so Mingus — the money was not there — and Mingus at this time weighed about three hundred pounds, probably 40 years old or so. He just tore the piano up. It was a Steinway grand, probably seven feet. He went inside the piano and took his fingers and plucked the strings, all that tension. You know piano wires hold locomotives. You know you can dangle a locomotive, that's their claim to fame of how strong the tension is. He goes in there and

plucks them out with his hands. And so Lonnie and I, we looked at that and here we are, we've auditioned to get in this man's band, and we're in his band now, and there he is over there tearing the piano up, three hundred pounds. We were like 20 years old, 19, 20. And it was like oh, man, we work for somebody like this. And these gangsters, this just shows you the power of psychosis. I don't care who anybody is, if you act, if you seem to be more crazy, crazier than they are, it's awesome. And everybody respects that. And they just didn't do anything to the guy. They probably could have killed him. But he was actually more bizarre, more outrageous than they were, and so they were just awestruck. They did owe him the money. He tore the piano up and then cut out.

MR: They really respected that.

CM: Well yeah I mean here's a guy that doesn't care anything about who you are or whether you're supposed to be this tough guy and this, because I'm crazy. And crazy people are tough. And they are, they really are. I mean I've grappled with some in the middle of — and they are, they're like ten men, and nobody did anything. And so Lonnie and myself, we were terrified at that time. And we went on and made the gig. I worked with Mingus for about 12 years off and on.

MR: And when you said that his music was difficult, well not only to play but—

CM: Well to interpret.

MR: To interpret, and did he write things out?

CM: Yeah he wrote things out and some things he didn't write out. It didn't make any difference. To write it out and look at it was as hard as it would be trying to play it without the music. Take your pick.

MR: There must have been a lot of tension.

CM: Yeah, it was. It was an extremely hard gig. And Mingus was never satisfied. He was a real task master and he was not a man easily satisfied. I don't think he was comfortable being satisfied. I think he was comfortable being on edge. And I mean that was comfort for him. In fact I can remember when everything was going really well, the music was great, people in the clubs were quiet, it almost, he didn't have an arena to vent something. And he would look like some little lost kid. Everything is fine and nothing to say. And he would almost pray for some poor soul out there from Cleveland to talk or drop a drink so that he could do his Mingusisms you know, which worked great, because then they would be in the paper, the next day there would be a line around the block getting in the club because Mingus took his bass and broke it or threw it up in the air. I mean it was good theater. But his music was good too so I mean I learned a lot from him musically.

MR: Stanley Crouch related, I guess it was the Monterey Jazz Festival or something he was talking about—

CM: Yes. '64.

MR: The thing with Mingus and how you and it was only — he ended up firing most of the band except you and a couple other players. But this was not that uncommon with him.

CM: No that was all part of it. No I mean Mingus fired himself. He would get mad at the musicians because they weren't playing his music right or whatever, and he would fire everybody. The whole band, including him. He would just tell the club owner, you know, this is not right, we're not playing, these guys are not right, I'm not right, we're not — of course the next night we were playing again.

MR: And there was a film about him that you were in too, wasn't there?

CM: Well that was some kind of documentary about Mingus being evicted. And that was part of the film, and maybe the film was about other things too. And that was an interesting thing. I think was working with Mingus at that time. It was a big deal. I mean you turn on the six o'clock news in New York and there's Mingus, the six o'clock news in New York City, being evicted. And it was a big deal, and everybody was there, and Mingus — oh it was really something. But you know he was good at, the guy was, besides a great musician and bass player, he also had a flare for doing, I don't know — controversy. And he could make that work. And it does work. And it wasn't, and he was actually being himself. All he had to do was be himself and this would be that. Anyway, so that worked for him.

MR: Did his compositions and playing on them force you to really expand your way of thinking about playing over changes?

CM: Oh, yeah. I mean in more than one dimension actually. Certainly that way but also I think I developed a sound, you know, like a certain power also with him. Because he was powerful, and his music was powerful and also you had to have power to be with him. Not just power in terms of audibility, which you definitely needed that, but another, a different — all the different manifestations of power. So I mean my professional teeth were really cut with that group. And yeah, he was hard, because he was very hard to please, so you were constantly trying to do that for him.

MR: Well you've been associated with the Charlie Parker school, but a lot of the things I've read too make the point that you eventually found your own sound. Was there a point where you felt that you had found your own sound?

CM: Oh yeah. When — it's not like I really — I guess I self produced a CD around 1990. It was live at a club here in San Diego. And just in listening to it one day, it dawned on me that you know I mean this is definitely a Bird influenced style/approach. But this really doesn't sound like Charlie Parker. This is really another kind of a deviation, it's off to the side a bit. And it really doesn't sound like Charlie Parker. I mean it has overtones of that. And so on a conscious level, it sort of dawned on me then. But I never tried to copy Charlie Parker. I mean he was definitely my main influence. I've always tried to go my

way into according to what I thought was aesthetically and musically the right way for me. And I never worried about that. Even though people would write or critics would always say something, it didn't bother me whether they could hear that or not. I didn't deliberately necessarily try not to sound like Charlie Parker, but I didn't really try to sound like him. I think there was just this influence, on a saxophone player, an alto player, playing this so-called modern music. And I play alto. So I mean there's going to be some similarity. Really I mean alto players sort of get the bad rap in a sense in terms of being compared with Charlie Parker. And that's mainly because you're playing the same instrument. If I took a trumpet solo of today, by anyone, transcribed it and played it on the alto saxophone, that solo would sound as much like Charlie Parker as, you know, you see? I mean Charlie Parker is so immense in terms of influence that there's not eight bars played since 1940 that some sort of way, that's totally divorced from Charlie Parker. That's how powerful he was. And you know people can play that on tenor, can play it on piano, guitar, trumpet, tuba, trombone, and the comparison will not be made because the instrument was different. But a saxophone player can have the influence of Charlie Parker, and then no one hears or sees anything else. So in a way it's unfair.

MR: Yeah. Well Louis Armstrong seemed to have the same — up until Parker he was kind of I guess the man who set the standard and most people were compared to him, especially the trumpet players, would be compared with him.

CM: Yeah, right. And you know the differences that manifest itself in a particular person, has to be heard in the public consciousness long enough for the difference to be solidified in other people's minds. You know what I mean? For them to say oh, this is a different style, this is Roy Eldridge. You know what I mean? Whatever that difference is, it has to be heard often enough by enough people, musicians, whatever, to be able to discern the little bit of difference. Because no two people are exactly alike. And the differences have to be discerned. Once they are discerned by enough people, industry people, other musicians, critics, writers, whomever is visible enough or heard enough for the people to know the difference between this and say Charlie Parker or Louis Armstrong, then that difference is no longer like this anymore, it's like this, because it's known. You see what I mean? And that's what happened to some people. You know if a martian came down to earth and listened to say Dizzy Gillespie, and say listened to Pete Candoli, to him it would sound the same. You know what I'm saying? But not to us, because if you know Pete and you know his style kind of sounds sort of like that, and Dizzy is this and that. But to a martian well it's like well it's the same one. What's the difference? And these little bit of difference only becomes bigger when you have isolated that difference.

MR: Can I ask you about the film "Bird," how that came about? You played some on the soundtrack.

CM: Right.

MR: Did you have to audition for that? Or were you just picked?

CM: Not really. The musical director for Clint Eastwood is — oh goodness — oh Lennie Niehaus, yes. And I think Lennie probably was familiar with me. He's an alto player you know. And somebody recommended me, and Lenny got in touch with me. And I sent him a tape or something and he liked it and that was it. And so that was interesting to do. I wasn't involved in any visual part of the film, so it was just the soundtrack.

MR: And you'd go in and record the tunes, and then the fellow that played him had to match up to, or try to.

CM: Yeah, the best, you know, pantomime. A lot of things they were able to retrieve and use from Charlie Parker. Some things they were not able to do either because of the technology of it, or because of contractual situations like money or whatever. And in those instances I was involved. And then there were incidental scenes during the movie where certain background things needed to be, and of course Bird's not there, and well they didn't use him for things like that. There was one scene in the movie involving Charlie Parker riding in Beverly Hills with this woman, and she was showing him all the houses and things, you know, Humphrey Bogart's mansion and then they rode farther and here's Melvin Douglas' or whatever. And this is supposedly true. And Bird really expressed really no heck of an interest, other than, "Oh yeah, really great, wonderful house." Whatever. Until she got to Igor Stravinsky's house. And of course this impressed him. He wanted to get, according to her he did get out of the car and just went up to this huge and massive gate and just kind of stared at the house, I mean, because he had respect for Igor Stravinsky. And Clint Eastwood suggested for this scene that I play a Kansas City style blues, and that would be superimposed on Stravinsky's "Firebird Suite." So and that was his suggestion, and I thought that was a nice arty thing to do, and it worked great because he had "Firebird Suite" going on and then this Kansas City blues on top of that.

MR: Was there any attempt to figure out, well, what key is his piece in?

CM: Well it didn't make any difference. In fact, the fact that it was happening, it was just super — it was like Charles Ives, it was just superimposed, it didn't make any difference. And in fact it worked really well, it was very, very interesting.

MR: That's quite a combination.

CM: So it was interesting how that Hollywood click track stuff works and just the technology and how they write music for scenes, you know I'd never done that before.

MR: Has there been a period of years that were the toughest to make a living as a jazz musician for you and your—

CM: After I stopped working with Mingus in 1972 maybe, it became a little rough. Mingus did work a lot and it was easier for me, but when I started working with my own group or being on my own, it was harder. So there was period, probably in the middle to late, I would say late 60s, it was meager. But then things got better.

MR: You were still living in New York?

CM: Yeah, I lived in New York up until around 1978. And then I moved to San Diego. And the reason I moved was because my mom still lives here, and I'm an only child, she was getting on in age and I thought I should be with her and hang out with her. So I actually came out just with the intentions of staying maybe six months, or three or four months, you know, like a lot of people I ended up staying. And then I married. I'm married now and I've got a little girl five years old.

MR: Oh, wonderful.

CM: And so I'm settled. But I don't work here in San Diego that often. There's not very much happening here jazz-wise.

MR: You have to travel.

CM: So I have to travel, which I don't mind at all. I don't mind doing it.

MR: And you have an older son who's a drummer?

CM: Yeah, I have an older son, Chuck, that plays drums, and I have another daughter and another son. I have two sons, two daughters. And Chuck is about 38 years old now and he works with me a lot. Sometimes he works with Harold Land, Freddie Hubbard, you know, and then I try to keep him working.

MR: Help get him some connections. You've gotten some pretty interesting liner notes from Stanley Crouch. He certainly has a way with words.

CM: I would say so.

MR: And he says, "McPherson never lets us forget the actual greatness of the art he represents."

CM: Oh, that's nice.

MR: Was there a point, did you always think of jazz — this is a tough question—

CM: No, it's all right.

MR: Did you always think of jazz as an art form? And if not, do you?

CM: Well I started playing when I was 13, 14 years old, and I started playing or trying to play jazz. Okay so by the time I was 18 or 19, I don't know if I actually thought of it as being art. I don't know if I even though about art at all. Because I was too busy trying to just learn how to play, just the academics of playing it. And definitions and things, to some 18-, 19-year-old kid, is just like meaningless. You know I didn't think. Now, since then of course I think of it as art. And the older you get you start thinking about definitions and all that stuff. And by the time you're 35 years old you're into defining everything.

But as a youngster, I never thought of it. I don't think I thought of classical music as an art. Probably I thought only art was a picture. You know what I mean? And that's it. But now I mean, or just from a certain point say of a young man, I thought of it, you know you start thinking of the frame of reference this and that and all that. And yeah, I mean art is a broad, you could almost say anything is art. That's art right there what you're doing. So you know, when you think about it, I don't know. Art is almost anything that human beings do that actually alters, to some degree, whatever God or nature does. I mean everything in nature is already there. I mean there's sounds, there's some kind of music, you know there's birds singing, there's trees falling, there's wind blowing. Everything has a note. To us it sounds unorganized and maybe it is maybe it isn't. But the minute that it becomes organized or if we think so, by humans, then it's the beginning of art right there, along with the vanity. You can't have art without vanity of some sort.

MR: I like that statement.

CM: In the broad sense of the term, I'm not saying egotism, but the fact that you even care is vanity.

MR: In that you have a desire to make it better.

CM: The desire, and also to want to look at it after it's done, you know what I mean? It's all this vanity. It's vanity. If you did these things and just said [grunts] and then walked away and never want to hear it, never want to see it, you could say it's devoid somewhat of vanity. But it becomes art. I think of black and white photos like art, as opposed to maybe color photos. I'm being a little bit — only because black and white is something that man does. It's more of an imprint of a human being or something. Color is something that's already here. I mean it's in nature you see. So I mean black and white photos are more arty. It's just my subjective opinion. But there's more of an artness to them in some sort of way. You know there's a starkness and stuff. So when you look at it like that, certainly music and writing and painting and all that stuff is an art.

MR: Isn't it interesting too that the vast majority of great jazz photographs you see are in black and white.

CM: Oh yeah. Everything. Movies. Would you like to see "The Maltese Falcon" in color? What's the point. Maybe "Gandhi" in color, but not "Casablanca" in color, I mean who needs the color? In fact the aesthetic is the fact that there isn't any color. Because then it leaves all the imagination. So yeah, I think jazz is a great art form. The endeavor certainly. Of course it's a difficult music. It relies heavily on improvisation, which is very difficult because everybody doesn't do that well. The name of the game is to do that. But because you are dealing with the spontaneity, that's what can make it difficult and not sound so good sometimes. So to pull it off you have to be expert or something, you have to be something, to pull it off.

MR: If you play a tune, if you're playing on "All the Things You Are," have you internalized that tune enough over the years that you don't have to think about this Two-Five-One and that.

CM: Oh yeah. In pretty much all music. You have to do that when you're maybe learning a tune. But once the tune is committed to memory, the form, the structure and the elements that make the tune what it is, I don't think any real pro that's been playing for a number of years really thinks about that. It's pretty much like when you're getting ready to talk you don't really say I'm saying an infinitive, I'm saying this is a verb, this is an adjective phrase, you don't really say that. You just need to say whatever it is you want to say and then you try to do it. And you do do it. So it's pretty much the same way.

MR: I like that analogy. Do you teach?

CM: Well I've done it. I have done it.

MR: You have taught. And I'm wondering if that's something that would be really important to pass on to a student, not to neglect learning songs really well because all the theory will not come into play until you know the song.

CM: Right. Yes. You have to know the literature that you're dealing with. So I mean it's just like anything else, you might go to school for journalism or for whatever, or for what he's doing. It doesn't make any difference what it is. You have two dimensions to conquer. You have the physical dimension or the physical media that you're dealing with, whether it's music, if it's writing, if it's — it doesn't make any difference. There's a certain thing that has to be overcome and you have to get the professionalism and the command over whatever medium it is. And then after that's done then that's not really the real main event. The main event is what do you do with that now? What kind of pictures do you take, or what kind of story. You can go to school and learn how to write, but okay now after you know the elements of how to write a short story or a long story, essay, this and that, all right, you know mechanically what to do, when, where, you know this is supposed to unfold in this manner and climax here and this here. But now that doesn't mean you're going to be a great writer. It just means you know the elements of writing. It's the same with music. You can learn Two-Five-Ones, chorus, and yes you should learn that and you will learn it and you do learn it. But that doesn't mean you're going to be a great soloist. It doesn't mean you're going to be a great artist. It doesn't mean any of that, because there's another aspect of all of that that has nothing to do with the physicality or the medium through which you're dealing, it's got something to do with all that other stuff, all that abstract stuff that you can't hold or touch, that there's no way in school they can show you. You can learn facts, figures and knowledge. But discrimination and wisdom can not be taught. That is something that you come wired with, or if indeed there is such a thing as people learning how to do it — I'm still out on

that, I don't know if you come wired with it, or if indeed something can be — there's some sort of way of learning, or your environment and all this stuff. Maybe that has something to do with something. But I know that you can't teach — I don't know that you can teach these things. How to write a great story. How to play a great solo. How to write great music. That's something else, and that's something that you deal, as an artist, this is what you're dealing with after you get past academia and all of that stuff. Then it's like how to get the best out of yourself when you want to, all the time. And how to have a certain, to maintain a certain level of whatever it is.

MR: Well spoken.

CM: Yeah. That's the whole thing.

MR: Can we get a shot of you holding your horn? I'm trying to recognize what kind of horn.

CM: It's a King. Most people play a Selmer, and this is a King Super 20.

MR: Yeah. Cannonball used to play.

CM: Yeah Cannonball and Bird. Yeah. And it's a very nice horn, it's very human-like. Very much like the human voice.

MR: It's interesting you say that because when I hear your tone, I mean I like — actually the thing that attracts me to a player is the tone first. And I hear that in your sound. And I noticed when Cannonball switched from King to Selmer I think that I was disappointed.

CM: Unbelievable. I mean I know that. But I'm surprised that — well you said you play saxophone.

MR: Yeah, but I heard it.

CM: And you heard the difference.

MR: I heard the difference.

CM: Isn't that something, because I did too. And so you really do know. Because that's a subtle thing, but it is a difference. And I remember it as a CD or record, whatever, where he did play Selmer for a while. And it was great, and it's still great 'cause he's great. And I remember that oh this is great, but it was like, you know it doesn't have that pop, or that warmth either. Because there was something — but it's still great. And the Selmer is a great horn you know, and he sounded great on it. But this King, it was just something about that that, I don't know just Cannonball sounded great on this. And Charlie Parker sounded great on this horn. I've heard other people on this horn that don't sound so great, and I hope I'm not one of them.

MR: No. You grow into an instrument and—

CM: Yeah. But it's a nice — I could say this too — one of things about jazz, at least for me, and just from the little history that I've read about certain performers and the origins in the beginnings of jazz music, one thing that might be different in some sort of way about the early musicians, like Buddy Bolden, I mean way back, is that I think they, either on a

conscious level or unconscious, always thought of an instrument as trying to make it sound like the human voice, as opposed to I'm playing the saxophone so I want it to sound like a saxophone. Now of course I want it to sound like a saxophone. But I really want it to be an extension of my voice, the humanity, the human situation with it. And I don't want to commit any errors in like making it sound like unsaxophonish. I want it to sound like a saxophone. But I'm really trying to make this sound — I'm bending and making and trying to make this horn sound like my voice as much as possible, as opposed to I'm just playing a saxophone. And this is probably why — part of the elements that make jazz what it is, like bending the note, not being literal but being surrealistic to a point where you want an impression of a note, and all these little elements that make it what it is, probably comes from that thought process. Because the voice bends. When you sing a note, any singer, I don't care who it is, it doesn't have to be a jazz singer, they sing the note but there's a natural tendency to slightly bend the note a bit because it's human and it's something to do with the right kind of emotionality. It's the right thing to do. Horns, you know when guys think of a horn as just a mechanical-physical frozen structure, and they're not thinking humanity, then they tend — it tends just to be that. But if you're thinking, I want this to be an extension of my voice, then you are going to bend these notes, you are going to have an impressionistic. Because you're not just playing a piece of metal. You're making this be human as much as possible.

MR: Maybe that's the art we were talking about.

CM: Well it's certainly part of it, yeah, definitely.

MR: I'm going to let him flip over the tape and then we'll wrap up here.

CM: Did you get enough shots with the horn here or should I keep it out? Okay, I'm going to put it back.

But that's interesting that you hear that difference, that Cannonball and that Selmer. That's really something.

MR: It had some soul man.

CM: Yeah, really. And more humanity, and more pop, you know it has that more living. I don't know how — it's just a certain presence. It's like more present or something. Really that's what attracted me to this horn. And of course Charlie Parker is the one that really made this horn famous you know. And I really do think that part of that pop and that articulation that you associate with Bird and Cannonball, oh, shoot, well I'll tell you what —

MR: We'll just wrap up.

CM: Well I'll leave it, that's okay. I think that's got something to do with how they articulate. There's something special about Cannonball and Charlie Parker, in that articulation.

MR: Oh, yeah.

CM: And I think a lot has got something to do with this horn, I'll tell you. I hope we're okay.

MR: Yeah, we're okay. Do you have an opinion about where jazz is at in 1998?

CM: I don't know if it will ever be a mass media music. Maybe I'm wrong. I do think it will always be. There will always be jazz. I think it's too much in the public consciousness, in the world consciousness. You know what I mean? The world is a smaller place now, so CDs and records can go to China, they can go to Russia, they can go to Africa, wherever they go there's always going to be somebody in wherever, that's going to hear records, and say whatever this is, I like this. So it will always be. Now, whether it will ever be different or whether it will not be an esoteric kind of music, I almost think it might always be that. And I don't know if that's good or bad. But it would be nice if everybody would like it and it became a popular mass. But I don't see how that could be.

MR: I don't either.

CM: Why is that now? What does that mean?

MR: I think jazz needs — you said a word a while back in something you were talking about, you used the word "discriminating" or "discrimination." It needs a very discriminating listener. You have to work at it a little bit, I think, to like it. And I don't know if everybody's—

CM: So inclined. But it's weird. Yeah, I'm still out on that. Sometimes I wonder if it just doesn't rub people, you know everybody's not going to be enamored of it, no matter how they're exposed. You know some people say, oh to expose it more, and you heard it, and that's probably true to a point. You know what I'm saying? I'm sure that you're going to get more people if it was exposed more, that's true. But at the same time, I don't know if there are some people who will just not like that or who will not care. And some people really will.

MR: I think you can say that about — if more people are exposed to opera —

CM: More people would like it. But there's going to be people that say hey what is that, but there's people that wouldn't like it any way at all.

MR: I don't think it would make that much of a difference. Well this has been a real pleasure for me.

CM: Well thank you so much.

MR: And I'm glad that you were able to come tonight, and I appreciate some of your very insightful thoughts and comparisons. So on behalf of Hamilton College, thanks so much.

CM: Well thank you.